

BT Group - Company Research

What BT is, who runs it, what it is doing right now, and why you want to join

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Study pack - part 5 of 9

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Why this matters

“Why do you want to join BT?” is question 78 on your faculty’s list, so it is coming. The difference between a candidate who researched the company and one who did not is visible in about four seconds, and it is one of the few things you can guarantee you get right.

Everything below was checked against BT’s own site and current reporting on **12 August 2026**. Anything not fully confirmed is marked.

The 60-second version

If you remember nothing else, remember this:

BT Group is the UK's incumbent telecommunications company and **one of the oldest telecoms companies in the world**, tracing back to the Electric Telegraph Company of **1846**. It became British Telecom in 1980 and was **privatised in 1984**. Today it has four businesses: **Consumer** (including **EE**, the UK's largest mobile operator), **Business**, **International**, and **Openreach**, which builds and maintains the physical network that almost every UK broadband provider rents. The CEO is **Allison Kirkby**, in post since February 2024, and the headquarters is **One Braham, London**. BT has been in India **since 1987** and now has **over 12,000 employees** here, including an office in **Kolkata at DLF IT Park II**.

The facts

Full name	BT Group plc
Founded	Traces to the Electric Telegraph Company, 1846 - the world's first public telegraph company. Renamed British Telecom in 1980; privatised 6 August 1984 as British Telecommunications plc; became BT Group plc in 2001
Headquarters	One Braham , Braham Street, Aldgate, London , UK (moved there from the old BT Centre)
CEO	Allison Kirkby - appointed February 2024, the first woman to lead BT . Previously President and CEO of Telia Company , and before that CEO of TDC in Denmark. She was already on BT's board as a non-executive director before taking the job
Listed	London Stock Exchange (BT.A), a FTSE 100 company
Employees In India	Around 77,000 globally (FY26) Present since 1987 , starting with a single New Delhi office. Now over 12,000 employees

The four businesses - know these

Business	What it does
Consumer	Retail broadband, mobile and TV for UK households, under the BT , EE and Plusnet brands. EE is the UK's largest mobile operator - BT bought it in 2016
Business	Connectivity, networking, cloud and security for UK businesses and the public sector
International	Global networking and services for multinational customers - the part of BT that sells managed WAN, MPLS and security services worldwide
Openreach	Builds and runs the physical access network - the cables, ducts, poles and exchanges. Legally separate with its own board since 2017 , because it must sell to every provider (Sky, TalkTalk, Vodafone) on equal terms, not just to BT

Openreach is the one people get wrong. If you can explain that Openreach is structurally separated so that BT's competitors get the same wholesale terms as BT itself, you sound like you actually read

about the company.

What BT actually does, in plain terms

Four things, and your role sits inside the fourth:

1. **It owns and runs physical infrastructure** - fibre, copper, exchanges, mobile masts, subsea cables.
2. **It sells connectivity to consumers** - home broadband, mobile, TV.
3. **It sells connectivity and IT services to enterprises** - this is where WAN links, MPLS, site-to-site VPNs, managed routers and security live. **This is exactly the vocabulary of your job description.**
4. **It runs and assures all of that 24/7** - network operations centres watching alarms, tickets, incidents and escalations. **This is your role.**

Say this connection out loud in the interview if you get the chance. A Service Reliability Engineer at BT is not a peripheral function - keeping enterprise services up *is* the product that customers are paying for.

BT in India, and Kolkata

- BT has operated in India **since 1987**, from an initial office in New Delhi.
- **Over 12,000 employees** across Global Services, Technology, Corporate functions and Open-reach.
- **Office locations** (from BT's own India careers site):
 - **Gurugram** - three sites, including Infospace IT/ITES SEZ and DLF Cyber City
 - **Bengaluru** - three sites, including The Millennia and RMZ Ecoworld
 - **New Delhi** - Eros Corporate Tower, Nehru Place
 - **Kolkata - DLF IT Park II**
- BT's technology function in India describes itself as **1,800+ technology professionals across six locations in four states**, working on communications and AI research.
- India is a major delivery base for BT, not a small satellite - roughly a quarter of BT's global headcount.

Why this is useful to you: the Kolkata office is real and it is where you would likely work. Mentioning “the Kolkata office at DLF IT Park” naturally is a small, specific detail that reads as genuine interest rather than a generic answer. *(If they say the site is elsewhere, take the correction gracefully - listings change.)*

Recent developments - as of the FY26 results (year ended 31 March 2026)

This is your “I follow the company” material. You do not need all of it - **two facts said confidently beat ten recited**.

Financial picture: - Reported revenue **£19.7bn, down about 3%**; adjusted EBITDA roughly **flat at £8.2bn**; reported profit before tax **£1.4bn, up 8%**. The dividend was lifted. - FY27 guidance points to adjusted EBITDA of **£8.2-8.3bn** - so the story is flat-to-modest growth while costs come down.

The fibre story - the biggest thing happening at BT: - Openreach had a **record year of fibre build**, passing **4.8 million more premises**, and now reaches **over two-thirds of UK homes and businesses**. - **2.2 million net new fibre connections** in the year; Openreach broadband ARPU up 4% to £16.7. - The build target is around **25 million premises**, heading toward **30 million by 2030**. - The strategic point: BT is spending heavily now to replace the old copper network with full fibre, which should mean lower maintenance costs and better service later. This is the single most important thing to understand about BT today.

The pressures: - Openreach has been **losing broadband lines** to alternative network builders (the “altnets”) and to Virgin Media O2 - competition in UK broadband is intense. - **Cost transformation:** BT raised its savings target to **£3.7bn** (from £3bn) and extended the programme by a year to **FY2030**. - **Headcount:** the plan announced in 2023 to reduce to between **75,000 and 90,000 by 2030** is still running, and Allison Kirkby has said **AI could reduce headcount further** than previously planned. - **EE** grew its 5G base, adding postpaid mobile customers - mobile is the healthier side. - There has been recurring press speculation about a possible **separation or spin-off of Openreach**. Treat it as speculation, not fact, and do not raise it yourself.

How to use this without sounding rehearsed: pick the fibre build. “The thing that struck me reading about BT is the scale of the full-fibre rollout - two-thirds of the UK reached and heading for 30 million premises. That’s an enormous infrastructure programme, and it means the network keeps changing underneath the services that have to stay up, which is the part I’d be working on.”

The answer to “Why do you want to join BT?”

Do not memorise this. Understand why each piece is there, then say it in your own words.

“Three reasons, honestly.

The first is the scale and the age of the network. BT goes back to the telegraph in the 1840s and it’s still the company physically building the UK’s fibre network today - two-thirds of the country reached already. I’ve only ever run applications on one or two servers. The idea of working on infrastructure at national scale is genuinely a different level, and I want to learn at that level.

The second is the role itself. I’ve realised that the part of software I enjoy most isn’t writing features, it’s the part after - getting something running on a server, keeping it up, and working out why it broke. This role is that, but for real networks and real customers, which is a much bigger version of the same thing.

And the third is that it’s a place where I’d actually be taught. I’ve mostly learned alone from documentation and mistakes, which works but it’s slow and I know I’ve picked up gaps. A first-line team with people who’ve done this for years is where I’d learn the right way to do it, rather than my own way.”

Why this works: it is specific to BT (not swappable for any company), it is honest about your level, and it frames a first-line role as something you actively want - not a fallback. That last part matters more than you think, because they will worry a developer sees this as a stopgap.

The follow-up you must be ready for

“You’re a developer. Why do you want a network operations role?”

This is the most likely challenge in the whole interview. Answer it directly, without defensiveness:

“That’s a fair question. What I found is that the parts of my projects I actually enjoyed were the infrastructure parts - setting up the reverse proxy, getting the DNS and certificates right, reading logs at midnight to find why requests were failing. The coding was fine, but that was the part that held my attention. And I’d rather learn networking properly, inside a company that runs real networks, than keep picking it up in fragments around the edges of web projects. I know I’d be starting near the bottom of it. That’s fine - I’d rather start properly.”

Never say or imply “any job is fine” or “I’ll take this and move to development later”. That answer ends the interview in their heads even if they smile.

Questions to ask them

Always say yes to “do you have any questions for us?”. Have three ready, ask two.

Good ones:

1. “What does a typical shift actually look like for a first-line engineer here - is it mostly alarm-driven, or mostly customer-raised tickets?”
2. “For someone joining from a software background rather than a networking one, what does the first few months of training usually cover? Would something like CCNA be part of it?”
3. “What separates someone who does really well in this team from someone who just gets by?”
4. “How does the Kolkata team work with the UK side - is there a handover between regions, or does each region own its own queues?”
5. “Given how much of the network is being rebuilt with full fibre right now, does that change what the service assurance teams see day to day?”

Question 5 is your best one if the conversation has gone well - it proves you read about the company *and* connected it to the role.

Avoid as your first question: salary, shift allowances, leave policy, work-from-home, or “when will I get promoted”. Ask about the work first. If they raise shifts or compensation themselves, engage with it normally - it becomes a fair topic once they open it.

Do ask about shifts if it matters to you, but frame it as understanding the work: “Is this role shift-based, and how does the rota usually work?” That is a practical question, not a demanding one - and for a 24/7 operations role it is completely reasonable.

Small things that signal you did the work

- Say “**BT Group**” or “**BT**”. “British Telecom” is the historical name - not wrong, but dated.
 - **Openreach is separate.** It has its own board and sells to all providers equally.
 - **EE is BT’s mobile brand**, acquired in 2016, the UK’s biggest mobile operator.
 - The CEO is **Allison Kirkby**. If you name her, name her correctly and do not guess at anything beyond the public facts above.
 - BT is a **British** company - the interview will likely be in Kolkata, but the customers and much of the leadership are UK-based, which is partly why the JD stresses communication and “sensitivity to cultural diversity”.
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Sources

- BT Group corporate site and board pages - bt.com/about, [group businesses](#)
- BT history - [History of BT \(PDF\)](#)
- BT India careers site (locations, headcount, since 1987) - jobs.bt.com/content/India
- FY26 results to 31 March 2026 - [BT investor results release](#), [Investigate announcement](#)
- Kirkby appointment - [BT newsroom](#)
- Cost programme and headcount reporting - [DataCenterDynamics](#), [Mobile World Live](#)